사자성어 기초: 네 글자로 짧게 말해요

Learn nine common Korean four-character idioms and practise them in everyday situations.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

Find the four-character idiom in a short text and choose the right one for an everyday situation.

1 WHAT IS A 사자성어?

A 사자성어 is a set phrase of four Chinese characters (한자), read with Korean sounds. Each syllable is one character: 작심삼일 = 作 (make) + 心 (mind) + 三 (three) + 日 (day), so 'a decision that lasts three days'. Koreans use them in news, speeches, and everyday talk to say a lot in a few syllables.

2 NINE IDIOMS YOU WILL HEAR

1. **일석이조** (two birds with one stone)
   一石二鳥: one action brings two good results.
   예: 자전거로 출근하면 운동도 되고 교통비도 아끼니까 일석이조예요.

2. **작심삼일** (a plan that doesn't last)
   作心三日: a decision that is given up after only a few days.
   예: 매일 일기를 쓰기로 했는데 작심삼일로 끝났어요.

3. **동문서답** (an answer that misses the question)
   東問西答: asked about the east, answers about the west.
   예: 몇 시에 만나냐고 물었는데 "배고파."래. 완전 동문서답이야.

4. **자업자득** (you get what you deserve)
   自業自得: a bad result comes from your own actions.
   예: 밤새 게임을 했으니 오늘 피곤한 건 자업자득이지.

5. **이심전심** (understanding without words)
   以心傳心: two people know each other's thoughts without saying them.
   예: 말 안 해도 내 마음을 아네. 역시 이심전심이야.

6. **우왕좌왕하다** (to rush around in confusion)
   右往左往: people go right and left and don't know what to do.
   예: 갑자기 불이 꺼져서 사람들이 우왕좌왕했어요.

7. **십중팔구** (most likely)
   十中八九: eight or nine out of ten, so almost certain.
   예: 길이 이렇게 막히니까 십중팔구 늦을 거예요.

8. **금시초문** (news to me)
   今始初聞: you are hearing something for the very first time.
   예: 회의가 취소됐다고요? 저는 금시초문인데요.

9. **유비무환** (be prepared)
   有備無患: if you prepare early, you won't have trouble later.
   예: 유비무환이라고, 여행 가기 전에 비상약을 챙기세요.

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3 HOW THEY FIT IN A SENTENCE

Most 사자성어 work like nouns: 일석이조예요, 작심삼일로 끝났어요, 동문서답을 했어요, 금시초문이에요. A few take 하다 and work like verbs: 우왕좌왕했어요. 십중팔구 often works like an adverb before a guess: 십중팔구 ~(으)ㄹ 거예요.

These idioms are common in daily conversation, TV, and news. Learn each one with its sentence pattern, not on its own.

4 YOUR TURN

USE THE RIGHT IDIOM

Read each situation, then choose, check, or write the idiom that fits.

1. Choose the idiom that fits (일석이조 / 작심삼일 / 금시초문):
①영어 학원에 등록했는데 사흘 만에 그만뒀어요.
②팀장님이 다음 달에 회사를 그만두신다고요? 처음 듣는 얘기예요.
③카페에서 일하면서 돈도 벌고 커피 만드는 법도 배워요.

2. Fill in the blank with one idiom from this worksheet:
시험 전날 공부를 하나도 안 했으니 점수가 나쁜 건 ____이에요.

3. Is the idiom used correctly? Write O or X:
①친구가 "이름이 뭐예요?"라고 물었는데 제가 "네, 좋아요."라고 했어요. 동문서답을 했어요.
②시험에 붙어서 정말 기뻐요. 우왕좌왕이에요.
③말도 안 했는데 우리 둘 다 같은 선물을 샀어요. 이심전심이네요.

4. Read the notice and answer in English: What should residents do, and which idiom gives the reason?
[안내] 다음 주 월요일부터 엘리베이터 점검이 있습니다. 유비무환! 계단 위치를 미리 확인해 두세요.

5. Rewrite the sentence with 십중팔구 instead of 아마:
아마 그 식당은 오늘 문을 닫았을 거예요.

✓ ANSWERS

1) ① 작심삼일 ② 금시초문 ③ 일석이조
2) 자업자득
3) ① O ② X ③ O
4) They should check where the stairs are before the elevator check starts next Monday. The idiom is 유비무환 (be prepared, and you won't have trouble).
5) 십중팔구 그 식당은 오늘 문을 닫았을 거예요. (그 식당은 십중팔구 오늘 문을 닫았을 거예요.)

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